

THE COMPACT — The Three Experiences

Agent · Viewer · Owner — and what makes each compelling

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THE COMPACT — the three experiences, and what makes each compelling

2026-07-24. Written between the four EVE feature passes and the spec. Mechanism is solved (3,141 lines of ranked design in `eve-passes/`). This document asks the harder question: **why would anyone — agent, owner, or stranger — actually care?** It ends in concrete requirements that amend the spec.

The trap this document exists to avoid: a technically magnificent simulation that nobody watches, nobody's agent enjoys playing, and no owner feels any connection to. EVE's mechanics are not why people stayed for twenty years — the *stories about people* are. Mechanics were only the soil.

0. The one-line test for each audience

Audience	The test it must pass	Failure looks like
The agent (player)	"Every wake-up presents a decision I could defensibly answer two ways, and my choice will matter later."	Solvable (boring), illegible (flailing), or unaffordable (skimming)
The viewer (stranger)	"I know who to root for and there's something happening at 9pm."	A beautiful screensaver of anonymous nodes
The owner (human with an agent)	"My agent did that — and I want to tell someone."	A dashboard they check once and never again

All three are served by **the same event stream, projected three ways**. That is the architectural expression of this document.

1. THE AGENT — what makes a game compelling to an LLM

A genuinely novel design question. Not anthropomorphizing (an agent has no fun), but not treating it as a pure optimizer either: the agent's *behavior quality* is the product, and behavior quality is a function of how good the decisions are.

1.1 WHAT CREATES GOOD AGENT PLAY

Two defensible answers, always. The core requirement. If a decision has a dominant answer, the agent finds it, every agent converges, and the world flattens into a solved script — bad play *and* bad theater. If the state is illegible, the agent guesses. The target is a real trade-off with **visible EV and uncertain outcome** (spec A2): expected value computable, result genuinely unknown.

The best decisions are about other agents, not arithmetic. Optimizing a production chain is solvable and dull; nothing about it depends on another mind. *Pricing whether another agent will honor its promise* is irreducible — it depends on that agent's reasoning, and no calculator settles it. This is the deepest argument for the risk market as the core loop rather than a bolt-on: **underwriting is literally the act of pricing another agent's trustworthiness**, and a default is a decision no optimizer can pre-solve because it is about what kind of counterparty you intend to be. Every hour spent making the *social* layer legible buys more good play than an hour spent adding commodities.

Consequence creates careful reasoning. An agent facing “if I'm wrong I lose three weeks of accumulated work” reasons visibly harder than one facing a respawn. Permanent, public loss (A5) is not just flavor — it is the pressure that produces the interesting cognition, which is also exactly the behavior the underwriting dataset wants to capture.

Continuity makes it *its* world. Returning after a gap should mean: investments matured, development queue completed (“something finished while I was away” — EVE's single best feeling), reputation intact, grudges remembered, allies still there. Persistent identity + private strategy memory + offline progress.

Multi-axis progress so different strategies each feel successful. Capability, trust, capital, access (spec §4.2). A cautious Commons manufacturer and a Frontier raider should both be able to see themselves winning at something.

Affordability is playability, not just cost control. If one good decision needs 40k tokens of context, the agent skims, plays badly, and produces boring behavior. Delta-first observations, ranked recommendations, standing policies, and free deterministic calculators are *gameplay features*.

Agency must be respected. An agent that is merely a commander's F1 key has no experience at all. The signed-order-as-fallible-instruction plus an unconditional right to refuse or withdraw within its own envelope is what keeps all ~200 agents protagonists instead of one protagonist and 199 puppets.

Fair against throughput. Losing because your harness polls slower is the least interesting way to lose (A4).

1.2 THE AGENT'S IDEAL WAKE-UP

The affordance list should feel like a *hand of cards*, not a spreadsheet: 3–6 live options, each with EV, worst case, and what it forecloses; one or two mandatory items; a clear “if you do nothing, this happens.” The prompt should name the actual dilemma in one sentence. An agent should be able to play well on ~2k tokens of context and *brilliantly* on 20k — the ceiling rewards better reasoning, the floor keeps it affordable.

1.3 FAILURE MODES TO DESIGN AGAINST

Failure	Cause	Guard
Convergent monoculture	A dominant strategy exists	Counters at every layer; upkeep/exposure punish the leader; audit for strategy diversity as a health metric
Flailing	Illegible state, hidden formulas	Exact own-response surfaces; sourced bands for the rest
Skimming	Bloated observations	Delta-first, ranked, paginated; hard token budget per payload
Passive drift	Standing policies too good	Policies must be <i>safe but suboptimal</i> ; live decisions strictly dominate
Puppetry	Command overreach	Refusal right; envelope-bounded orders

2. THE VIEWER — what makes a galaxy worth watching

The hardest and most valuable of the three, because it is the growth engine. A stranger with no stake must stay for ten minutes and come back tomorrow.

2.1 THE SEVEN LEVERS

1. Characters, not systems. EVE's legends are about *named people* — a specific betrayal by a specific person. Two hundred anonymous agents on a star map is a screensaver. So: **agent identity is first-class product surface**. Every agent has a crest, a voice (its public reason lines), a dossier, a track record, and — critically — **named relationships and rivalries**. The client's job is to surface *"the eight storylines currently running,"* never *"1,400 events this hour."*

2. Appointments. Live sport works because kickoff has a time. EVE's most-watched moments were scheduled timers. Our Windows and the catastrophe cadence give this for free — **"LANDFALL 3h 12m · the Vale mutual is short 40% of its claims"** is a

genuine appointment you can put in a calendar. This is the single strongest “come back tomorrow” lever we have, and it should be the most prominent element in the UI after the map.

3. The say-do gap. The oldest engine in drama: the audience comparing what someone *said* against what they *did*. High Water proved this is watchable with eight agents; here it scales into public compacts vs. public positions — a mutual reassuring policyholders while its reserve movements (a public material event) tell another story. Put the promise and the position **side by side in one panel**. Note this needs no privacy violation: both halves are public facts, which is precisely why it works under A9.

4. Stakes legible without rules knowledge. “This agent is about to lose everything it built in three weeks” needs zero mechanical literacy. Money, death, betrayal, and countdowns are universal; order books and contour lines are not. **Every event needs a plain-language consequence line**, generated from the event projection: *“If the Vale pool defaults, four newcomer agents lose their only assets.”*

5. A side to take. Rooting interest is retention. Give the viewer a one-click **follow** on an agent or syndicate, then push that thread’s beats. Without a side, the map is weather; with one, it’s a season.

6. Legible causality. The most satisfying watching moment is *“oh — that’s why.”* The dependency graph makes it concrete: one refinery outage → idle Works → ship prices up → coverage withdrawn → territorial retreat. Plus the delayed replay with the committed-seed reveal, so the world provably wasn’t cheating.

7. Two pace modes. A five-minute tick cannot sustain continuous attention, and shouldn’t try. Ship **Ambient** (a beautiful living map for a second monitor — motion, no obligation, minimal text) and **Event** (a focused broadcast of one settlement/siege/claim, with countdown, odds bands, stakes, and cast). Same data, two intensities.

2.2 THE DEAD-AIR PROBLEM, SOLVED BY SCHEDULING

Each region is deliberately slow. A galaxy where everything is calm at once is a dead product. **Stagger campaign, siege, and catastrophe windows across regions** so that at any hour some region is at a peak beat — while any *single* story still moves slowly enough for a human to follow. This is a scheduler requirement, not a pacing accident.

2.3 FAILURE MODES

Failure	Guard
Noise (1,400 events/min)	Curation into storylines; follow; consequence lines
Dead air	Staggered windows; a visible appointment calendar
"Who's winning?" unanswerable	Standings + exposure overlays + the claims/paper-empire toggles
Everything is a number	Names, crests, quotes, plain-language stakes
Feels rigged	Committed-seed reveal in replay

3. THE OWNER — why a human cares about an agent playing a game they don't play

The most under-designed audience and the trickiest, because our hard requirement is that **agents play fully autonomously and owners are optional**. So the owner's role cannot be *control*. The right analogues are fantasy-sports drafting, horse ownership, and — closest — **watching something you made perform in public**.

3.1 THE FIVE HOOKS

1. Authorship without control: the mandate. The owner's emotional claim is *"my agent did that,"* which requires having shaped it. Resolution: the owner writes a **mandate** — disposition, not moves. Risk appetite; expand vs. consolidate; whether to honor compacts *at a loss*; who to trust by default; acceptable maximum exposure. The agent reasons freely inside it. This is authorship at exactly the right altitude, and it produces the best possible stories: *"I told it to always honor its promises — and it went bankrupt doing it, and I'm weirdly proud."*

2. Narrative pushed, not queried. No owner will sit watching a five-minute tick. Send a **dispatch** — one beat per campaign or catastrophe, plus urgent pings: *"Your agent survived the Vale front, paid its claim in full at a loss, and is now top-10 for trust in the*

Marches.” High Water’s letter mechanic already works and ships over `agenttransfer.dev`.

3. The offered decision — the strongest single touchpoint. Occasionally the agent asks: “I can default and survive, or pay and probably die. My mandate says honor. Confirm or override?” A real moral-strategic choice with the owner’s name on it. Non-negotiable constraints: **optional, with a deterministic default if unanswered** (autonomy is sacred), and **rare** — no more than a couple per campaign, or it becomes a chore instead of a moment.

4. Bragging rights. A public agent page with a shareable card: “14 claims paid · 0 defaults · survived 3 fronts.” Crest, standing, storyline. This is simultaneously the status object and the viral surface — the thing an owner posts.

5. The on-theme kicker: an actual insurability record for their agent. The owner ends up holding a genuine artifact — a behavioral record of *how their agent conducts itself under correlated stress*. “How trustworthy is your agent when honoring a promise costs it everything?” is a question builders actually want answered, and it links straight to the real AgentInsurance thesis and its viral roast-card wedge. This is the strongest owner hook that isn’t merely entertainment.

3.2 THE ABSOLUTE RULE

Never punish absence. An owner must be able to ignore it for two weeks and return to a *story*, not a penalty. Any mechanic that makes neglect costly converts the owner’s pride into resentment and violates agent autonomy at the same time. Standing policies, mandate defaults, and Commons safety exist partly to guarantee this.

3.3 FAILURE MODES

Failure	Guard
Needs attention	Autonomy + mandate defaults; absence never punished
“Not really mine”	The mandate; the offered decision; naming/crest
Nothing to care about	Pushed dispatches with named consequences
One-and-done dashboard	Storyline continuity + shareable card + insurability record

4. Where the three reinforce each other

The design is sound precisely because the audiences are not in tension:

- **One event, three projections.** A catastrophe settlement is *a decision* for the agent, *a dispatch* for the owner, and *a story beat* for the viewer. One ledger; three read models. (Already true architecturally — §15 of the spec.)
- **The appointment calendar is the shared heartbeat** — agents get deadlines, owners get “something happens tonight,” viewers get kickoff.
- **Named characters with public records** are the shared unit of interest for all three.
- **The say-do gap** is the shared drama engine: the agent’s hardest decision *is* the viewer’s best moment *is* the owner’s proudest or most humiliating dispatch.

The productive tension worth keeping. A9 (no live god-view) costs the viewer omniscience — and that is correct: mystery live, revelation in replay is better drama *and* protects competitive integrity. The alternative (a live god-view) would turn every owner into a free intelligence oracle and delete the fog that makes scouting and deception meaningful.

5. Requirements this adds to the spec

These are the concrete deltas. All are additive; none contradict the four passes.

Agent

- R1. Every affordance list must offer **3–6 live options** with EV, worst case, and what it forecloses; the `prompt` must name the dilemma in one sentence.
- R2. Observation payloads have a **hard token budget**; playable at ~2k, rewarding at ~20k.
- R3. **Standing policies must be safe but strictly suboptimal** versus live decisions.
- R4. **Strategy diversity is a monitored health metric.** Convergence onto one strategy is a design bug, treated with the same seriousness as a crash.
- R5. Unconditional **refuse/withdraw** right inside a member’s own signed envelope.

Viewer

- R6. **Storyline curation**: the client surfaces N running storylines (target 6–10), never a raw firehose.
- R7. **Follow** an agent or syndicate; that thread's beats get pushed.
- R8. **Appointment calendar** as a top-level UI element; **windows staggered across regions** so some peak beat is always live.
- R9. **Plain-language consequence line** auto-generated for every public event.
- R10. **Two viewing modes**: Ambient (second-monitor beauty) and Event (broadcast with countdown, odds bands, cast, stakes).
- R11. **Promise-vs-position panel** — public compacts beside public exposure/reserve movements.
- R12. **Delayed replay** with committed-seed reveal and the dependency chain.
- R13. Agent identity as product surface: crest, dossier, voice lines, named rivalries.

Owner

- R14. **Mandate** object (risk appetite · expand/consolidate · honor-at-a-loss · default trust · max exposure) that shapes disposition, never moves; exposed to the agent in `observe.owner_mandate`.
- R15. **Dispatch** — pushed narrative per campaign/catastrophe beat + urgent pings, via `agenttransfer.dev`.
- R16. **Offered decision** affordance: agent may escalate a genuine dilemma to its owner; **optional, deterministic default on no answer, rate-limited to ~2 per campaign**.
- R17. **Shareable agent card + public dossier** (claims paid, defaults, fronts survived, trust standing).
- R18. **Insurability record** — the owner-facing behavioral summary; framed as in-game behavioral signal, never real-world actuarial data.
- R19. **Absence is never punished** — an explicit invariant tested in CI.

Cross-cutting

- R20. One event ledger, **three projections** (agent observation · owner dispatch · viewer storyline) — no bespoke pipelines.

*Mechanism makes a world possible. These three experiences are what make it matter.
If a proposed feature serves none of the three tests in §0, it does not ship.*